

57 years is the mean age of heart attack victims in India

ON THE LONG ROAD: Average wait-time on city roads being 5 minutes, compared to the globally-acceptable 2 minutes, patients reach late

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FORGET AMBULANCE:

For a country with an estimated fleet of just 10,000 ambulances, only 5% heart attack victims avail the service

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DOOR TO DRUGS

Why don't heart attack victims get to the hospital in time? Here's how the roadmap of delay works in India...

TREATMENT: Most hospitals are not mobilised to provide timely cardiac care. At the hospital, a patient wastes 50 more minutes.

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LATE REACTION

SOMETHING I ATE: Too often people incorrectly diagnose a heart attack as indigestion, wasting time on antacids and emetics

LET'S VERIFY: A delay of 10 hours found on an average among patients who verify their symptoms with a local doctor first.

WHEN WILL I REACH: Lack of ambulance service, traffic congestion and long distance add to the delay

SHOW ME THE MONEY: Those with little or no insurance found to be late in seeking treatment. Nearly 75% Indians pay out of their own pocket.

treatments we now have," says Dr P. Joshi, cardiologist at the Government Medical College in Nagpur and one of the authors of the *Lancet* study.

The delays don't stop there. Most hospitals, it seems, are not mobilised to provide timely cardiac care. A patient on an average wastes 50 more minutes to get treated, compared to a waiting time of 20 to 30 minutes in the developed world. International studies confirm that the sooner "clot-busting" drugs are given to a heart attack patient, the better the chance of survival; timing is also critical in angioplasty (a procedure in which a balloon is inserted to open a blocked artery), the optimum time for which is in the first two hours; a delay of over two hours can mean a 40 to 60 per cent increase in mortality.

But why do people delay? Ask Anil Kumar. The 27-year-old software engineer had dismissed a discomfort in his chest as a bout of indigestion and popped in some antacid pills. By the time he was rushed to Manipal Hospital,

Bangalore, four hours had passed and what could have been saved by clot diluters turned into a major surgery. "When we think of someone having a heart attack, we think of them getting a sudden excruciating chest pain. But in a third of cases there's no pain at all," says Joshi. Sometimes people suspect a heart attack, but do nothing, hoping it will go away. Also people with symptoms go to a local doctor first. That's exactly what a smaller study at the Post Graduate Institute of Medical Education and Research in Chandigarh revealed in 2003. Over 10 hours were found to have been lost by patients who had visited a general practitioner.

The bulk of delayers were found to come in by private and public conveyance, with only 6 per cent using ambulance (the authors blame "lack of ambulance services, traffic congestion, long distances"). Also, those with little or no insurance were more likely to be late in seeking treatment (three-quarters of patients paid the hospital costs out of own pocket). "People don't realise that reaching late can be pocket-pincher," says Prabhakaran. "If you reach within

two hours, you can get away with simple clot-busting drugs which cost around Rs 1,500." An angioplasty, which works better when a patient reaches between three to six hours of symptom onset, costs around Rs 1,00,000.

So how can you be sure it's a heart attack and not something else? Medics provide the guidelines: Pain, tightness, pressure, heaviness or squeezing ("a steel band tightening around my chest" or "an elephant sitting on my chest"); and/or it spreads to the neck and throat, jaw, shoulders, the back and the hands; or a feeling of discomfort in the upper body. Perhaps a choking feeling in the throat with the arms feeling "heavy" or "useless"; difficulty in breathing, nausea, cold sweat, dizziness.

Tewari was lucky. It was a decisive moment when, despite initial hesitation, he sought help. Doctors insist that if your symptoms are severe, get worse quickly or last for 10 minutes or more, don't ignore. It's preferable to go to a hospital even if it turns out not to be a heart attack, than to stay at home until it is too late. Let not your heart attack take you by surprise. ■

any chest pain